



Appeal Decision

Site visit made on 11 August 2026

by A Wright BSc (Hons) MRTPI

an Inspector appointed by the Secretary of State

Decision date: 3 September 2026

Appeal Ref: 6009817

Woodside Equestrian Centre, Forest Road, Colgate, West Sussex RH12 4TF

- The appeal is made under section 78 of the Town and Country Planning Act 1990 (as amended) against a refusal to grant planning permission.
- The appeal is made by S Novell against the decision of Horsham District Council.
- The application Ref is DC/26/0206.
- The development proposed is the retention of top surface to majority of existing hardcore area and its use for the parking of vehicles in connection with the use of the equestrian centre and re

6. Policy S5 of the Framework states that only certain forms of development should be approved outside settlements. This includes development for rural businesses where a location outside settlements is shown to be necessary, with which Policy 26 of the HDPF is broadly consistent.
7. Policy 10 of the HDPF supports sustainable rural economic development where it is appropriate to the countryside location. It requires such proposals to contribute to diverse and sustainable farming enterprises, or for other countryside-based activities, contribute to the wider rural economy. In either case, the development must be accommodated within buildings appropriate for conversion or deliver substantial environmental improvement. This generally accords with Policy E4 of the Framework which sets out the types of development which should be supported to enable the sustainable growth of businesses in rural areas.
8. The proposed scheme includes re-siting the existing storage containers to a different position. These are used by various small mainly Horsham-based businesses to provide secure, affordable storage of equipment associated with their trade, such as building materials and carpets. They operate as a separate commercial activity which is not dependent on a rural location and could reasonably be accommodated within established employment areas. Therefore, in line with the Inspector's findings on the previous appeal for container and touring caravan storage on the property¹, the proposal is not essential to a countryside location. As such, it conflicts with Policy 26 of the HDPF.
9. Revenue from the appellant's equestrian business has been reducing for some time and the rental income from the containers subsidises the losses from this, enabling the retention of a small number of employees. Nonetheless, the proposed storage containers are not functionally linked to the equestrian or other land-based rural use. Whilst they help with the viability of the existing equestrian business, the commercial storage use does not diversify a farming enterprise, contribute to the wider rural economy or deliver environmental improvement, nor is it within a converted building. Therefore, it fails to accord with Policy 10 of the HDPF.

13. The site is within the High Weald National Landscape (HWNL) where there is a statutory duty to seek to further the purpose of conserving and enhancing the natural beauty. In addition, Policy N4 of the Framework states that proposals within National Landscapes (NLs) should be limited in scale and extent and sensitively located and designed to avoid harm to the statutory purposes and special qualities of the landscape. It requires substantial weight to be placed on the importance of conserving and enhancing the natural beauty of NLs.
14. Policy 30 of the HDPF generally reflects the statutory and national policy requirements. It also requires proposals within protected landscapes, including the NL, to have regard to the management plan for the area and to demonstrate how key components of natural beauty will be conserved, amongst other things.
15. Having regard to the High Weald AONB Management Plan, the HWNL is one of the best surviving medieval landscapes in north-west Europe. Its natural beauty is derived from the essentially rural and small-scale landscape character, rich in wildlife and cultural features, created by historic and locally distinctive agricultural and forestry practices. Features include abundant ancient woodland, and a mosaic of fields created by woodland clearance often bound by hedgerows and woods.
16. The Horsham District Landscape Character Assessment outlines the characteristics of the St Leonard's Forest Landscape Character Area (LCA) within which the site lies. This character area is very densely wooded, with the combination of forest cover and ghylls creating a strongly enclosed landscape with confined views. It includes a medium scale field pattern of regular arable fields which divide the woodlands. This area is identified as being highly sensitive to change, including from suburbanisation and changes in farmland management.
17. The appeal site comprises an equestrian use within a wider open area of paddocks and fields surrounded by tree belts and woodland. Therefore, the site and its setting are characteristic of the HW

20. The roadside vegetation provides some screening of the proposed parking area in views from Forest Road, which could be enhanced by additional native hedgerow planting along this boundary. However, parts of it would remain apparent in views into the site at the access point, through which the containers would also be evident. In any event, the high protection afforded to NLs does not exist only in visually prominent locations. The top-surfaced area, its use for parking and the installation of containers would erode the largely open, undeveloped landscape character. Although this erosion would be relatively localised, the proposed scheme would not conserve and enhance the natural beauty of the HWNL.
21. Consequently, I conclude that the proposal would fail to conserve and enhance the natural beauty of the HWNL. This would be contrary to Policies 25 and 30 of the HDPF which amongst other things seek to protect landscape character, including by conserving and enhancing the natural beauty of the HWNL. The proposal would also conflict with Policy N4 of the Framework and would therefore not further the statutory purposes of protected landscapes.

Other Matters

22. The Council did not find harm or development plan conflict in relation to the impact on ancient woodland. Nonetheless, even if I were to agree with the Council on this point, the absence of harm would be a neutral matter which would not carry weight in favour of the proposed scheme.

Planning Balance

23. As set out above, the proposed containers provide secure, affordable storage for nearby businesses and an